







NOT TOO FAST (Clockwise from left) Dry gin Baagh; Maia Laifungbam with her eponymous sake; aperitif Quro; jaggery-distilled rum Amrut Bella; Maya Pistola's Agavepura; Davana Vermouth Indica

announced her eponymous sake. In the absinthe category, there is La' Ananta and Paapi, a coffee absinthe. Among liqueurs, distinctive ones include Quaffine (coffee), Yagawilde (herbal), and Indian-born aperitif Quro, made with 36 ingredients.

"We wanted it to feel like a genuine attempt at capturing India in a glass," says Anmol Bansal, founder, Inspired Spirits Pvt. Ltd, creators of Quro. "We experimented with over 200 ingredients before settling on 36. The goal was always a unique, well-rounded drinking experience: from a first bright citrus note, followed by herbs and warm spices, and a pleasant, approachable bitterness to finish," he says.

Globally, vermouth too can be enjoyed chilled, over ice or in simple spritzes. However, in India, the category had not been deeply explored. This changed with Davana Vermouth Indica, the first 100 per cent homegrown creation, made with Indian wine and native botanicals. "Bartenders appreciate its cocktail versatility, while consumers are discovering it as a low-ABV alternative. The flavour complexity of Indian botanicals allowed us to build something layered, aromatic, and genuinely enjoyable neat or with ice, helping make vermouth less intimidating," explains founder Adarsh Gadvi.

What continues to provide impetus to such creations is the Indian consumer, who is today willing to explore premium regional ingredients, products and their expressions in the spirits space. That these liquids hold immense potential to carve a unique Indian flavour niche in the global spirits world is simply the next step forward. ■

—Ruth Dsouza Prabhu

JOLLY INDIAN, *Chennai*

True to name, this hot new spot in Alwarpet—with bold, kitschy interiors steeped in nostalgia—aims to be a 'fun-dining' rather than a 'fine-dining' experience. The pan-Indian menu has two sections throughout, the 'regular' stuff and then something 'jolly'—which is their quirky take on classic Indian dishes. Think Chettinadu shepherd's pie or a red snapper ceviche! The drinks are fun too—like Poppins, which has a rainbow popsicle dipped in grapefruit soda.





BAR SAMA *Bengaluru*

The highlight of this neighbourhood-style bar in Ulsoor Road is, of course, the drinks menu, which has been curated by Singapore's Cat Bite Club and includes playful riffs on classic cocktails—like Velvet Eclipse, a 'reverse' Irish Coffee. The Thai-inspired small plates menu holds its own against the drinks, with dishes like the Yum Sum-Oh! (pomelo and young coconut salad), grilled eggplant (see pic), Dirty Fried Rice, Night Market Moo Ping (coconut-glazed pork skewers), Panaeng Chicken Skewers, and the Moo & Goong (prawn and pork sesame toast). Encapsulating both the chaos and calm of Bengaluru, Bar Sama hopes to foster a sense of community.